

The Hidden Spring of the Spiral Cave

Explorer's story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1: The Bridge That Wasn't Built

The map looked like it had been folded and unfolded a thousand times, and maybe it had. The creases ran like tiny rivers across the paper, and the inked lines had softened into a careful blur.

Mara Denslow held it steady while wind tugged at her scarf. Below her boots, the cliff edge dropped into a green gorge where mist drifted like slow smoke. Across the gap, a natural bridge arched between two walls of stone—an enormous rib of rock, pale and smooth, as if the mountain had decided to hold its own hand.

“You’re sure this is the place?” asked Jory, her young field assistant, trying to sound brave while his backpack squeaked with every nervous shift.

Mara’s voice stayed calm, the way it always did, even when the world looked like it might crumble. “If the journal is right, the spring is beyond the bridge. A natural source with unusual mineral content. Some people say it heals. Others say it... does stranger things.”

“Stranger than healing?” Jory peered into the mist. “Like turning you into a frog?”

“I would consider that unhelpful,” Mara said, and her dry tone made Jory snort.

They weren’t here for legends, at least not officially. Mara had been invited by the valley villages to confirm whether the spring existed at all. The river that fed them had run low for two summers, and people were walking farther each month for clean water. If this spring was real, it could change everything—if they could reach it and if it was safe to share.

Mara looked at the bridge again. Up close, it wasn’t just a smooth arch. The surface was patterned with shallow grooves, like something had scraped it long

ago in repeating lines. Some grooves formed shapes that felt almost like letters.

“Do you see that?” she asked.

Jory squinted. “Like... scratches?”

“Like marks,” Mara corrected gently. “Deliberate ones.”

She ran her fingers over the stone. It was cool and faintly damp, even in the sun. Somewhere inside it, water might be traveling through hidden veins.

Jory swallowed. “So we just... walk across?”

Mara tightened the strap of her pack. “We walk across carefully. Courage is useful, but so is watching where you put your feet.”

They stepped onto the natural bridge. The gorge air rose cold against their faces, smelling of wet leaves and stone. Wind hummed through the gap under them, a deep, steady note like the world’s own breathing.

Halfway across, Jory stopped. “Mara?”

“Yes?”

He pointed. On the far side of the bridge, carved into the rock wall, was a circular symbol—three curved lines swirling around a dot in the center.

Mara’s pulse ticked faster, but she didn’t let it show. “That matches the journal.”

“So someone’s been here.”

“Someone,” Mara agreed, “and they wanted to be remembered.”

Chapter 2: The Whispering Wall

On the far side, the ground rose into a narrow passage between cliffs. Ferns clung to cracks like green hands. The path was shaded, and the temperature dropped as if they'd stepped into a stone hallway.

Mara took out a small notebook and sketched the symbol. "Three spirals. Water, wind, and earth—common meanings. But the dot..." She frowned.

"The dot is like the spring?" Jory offered.

"Or the heart of it."

They followed the passage until it widened into a small basin surrounded by sheer rock. At the center stood a wall of stone, smooth and vertical, as if it had been sliced by a giant blade. More carvings covered it—lines, circles, and a long band of tiny marks.

Jory ran a hand along the band. "These look like little footprints."

"They're tally marks," Mara said. "Counted. Measured."

"Counted what?"

Mara didn't answer right away. She crouched near the base of the wall. A thin crack ran along the bottom edge, and from it came a faint sound: not quite a voice, not quite water. A soft, constant whisper.

Jory leaned in, eyes wide. "It's talking."

"It's flowing," Mara corrected, though her own skin prickled. "Water moving through rock can make sound. Like wind through reeds."

"Still," Jory said, "it sounds like it's saying something."

Mara pressed her ear near the crack. The whispering seemed to shift, rising and falling as if it had rhythm. She pulled back and studied the carvings again, letting her mind settle the way she did before a climb—steady, observant, patient.

“The marks aren’t random,” she murmured. “They’re instructions.”

Jory’s voice came out small. “Instructions for what?”

Mara traced a spiral with her pencil, then followed a line that ended at a carving shaped like an open hand. “For opening something.”

She stepped back and scanned the wall. No obvious door. No handle. Just stone, carvings, and the whisper.

Jory tried a joke, but it wobbled. “Maybe you just say, ‘Open sesame,’ and it opens.”

Mara’s lips twitched. “Worth trying later, if logic fails.”

She noticed that some carved lines pointed downward toward a cluster of rocks at the basin’s edge. They looked ordinary—until she saw that one had the spiral symbol on it, faint and worn.

Mara knelt and brushed away dirt. The rock wasn’t fixed. She gripped it and heaved. It shifted with a gritty scrape, sliding aside like a stubborn drawer.

Jory blinked. “Hidden lever rock. Of course.”

Mara slid it farther. Beneath it was a hollow, and inside the hollow lay a round stone disc engraved with the same three spirals and dot. It fit perfectly in her hands, surprisingly warm compared to the cliff.

The whispering grew louder the moment she lifted it.

Jory stepped back. “Uh... Mara?”

Mara held the disc up to the wall. Near the center of the carvings was a shallow circular dent, exactly the size of the disc.

She placed it in the dent. For a second nothing happened.

Then the wall shivered.

A thin seam appeared, running down the stone like a line drawn by light. With a low, grinding rumble, the wall split open, revealing darkness beyond and a breath of air that smelled sharply of minerals—like rain on hot pavement.

Jory stared. “Well. That’s... not normal.”

Mara’s voice stayed even, though wonder tugged at it. “Ancient engineering,” she said. “Or ancient geology guided by clever people.”

A narrow opening yawned before them. Inside, faint blue-green light glimmered like distant glowworms.

Mara adjusted her headlamp, but she didn’t turn it on yet. “We go slowly,” she said. “And we leave no mess behind. Whoever built this protected it for a reason.”

Jory nodded, gulped, and followed her into the unknown.

Chapter 3: The Cavern of Blue Light

The passage sloped downward, and the air grew cooler with each step. Water dripped somewhere, steady and patient. Mara’s boots found damp stone, and the sound echoed softly, as if the cave was listening.

The blue-green light came from veins in the rock—thin streaks that glowed faintly, like the cave had swallowed a piece of the night sky and forgotten to spit

it out.

Jory reached out and stopped himself at the last second. "Can I touch it?"

"Not yet," Mara said. "We don't know what minerals are in it. Some are harmless. Some are... unfriendly."

"Unfriendly minerals," Jory repeated, trying the words on like a new hat. "Great."

The tunnel opened into a cavern so wide Mara couldn't see the far wall. Stalactites hung like stone teeth. Below, a shallow lake spread out, perfectly still, reflecting the glowing veins in rippling stripes.

At the edge of the lake stood three stone pillars, each carved with spirals and hand symbols. Between the pillars, a narrow footpath of flat stones led across the water toward a small island in the center.

On the island, a plume of mist rose, pale and swirling. It wasn't drifting randomly; it curled as if drawn by a gentle spiral.

Jory whispered, "That's it. That's the spring."

Mara's chest tightened—not with fear, but with the heavy feeling of being close to something important. "Most likely," she said.

They stepped onto the stone path. The lake water looked dark, but when Mara leaned closer, she saw tiny bright specks drifting in it, like dust caught in sunlight.

Jory's foot slipped on a damp stone. His arms windmilled.

Mara grabbed his backpack strap and hauled him back. "Slow," she said, firm but not angry. "Resilience means you recover. Wisdom means you don't repeat the same mistake."

Jory breathed out shakily. “I’m recovering. I’m so resilient right now.”

Mara allowed a small smile. “Good.”

They reached the island. At its center, a crack in the stone released water that shimmered faintly, as if it carried light inside it. The water gathered in a natural bowl, then overflowed in a thin stream back into the lake.

The mist rose from where the water touched the air. Mara crouched and held a clear sample bottle under the flow. The water looked ordinary—until it hit the glass. Then it glowed softly, the same blue-green as the cave veins.

Jory leaned in. “It’s like it’s alive.”

“It’s mineral-rich,” Mara said, though she felt the same strange awe. “Possibly bioluminescent bacteria, or a reaction with the glass... We’ll test it.”

As she capped the bottle, the cave’s whispering returned—not from the wall this time, but from the air itself. It seemed to circle them, soft as breath.

Jory pressed his hands to his ears. “Okay, that is definitely whispering.”

Mara listened carefully. The sound rose and fell in patterns. Not words, but warnings. Like the hush you give someone near a sleeping baby.

“Mara,” Jory said, voice tight, “what if we’re not supposed to take it?”

Mara looked at the spring. Then she looked at the stone pillars. At their bases were grooves—channels carved to guide water. The spring wasn’t hidden to keep it from everyone forever. It was hidden to control how it was used.

“We’re supposed to be careful,” Mara said. “Not absent.”

She took out her notebook and drew the layout—pillars, path, channels. Then she noticed something carved into the island stone, half covered by mineral

crust: a hand symbol, but this one had two hands—one offering, one receiving.

Jory crouched beside her. “That’s... like sharing.”

Mara’s voice softened. “Yes.”

The whispering eased, as if the cave approved.

Then, from the tunnel behind them, came a sharp crack—stone on stone—followed by a distant rumble.

Mara stood fast. “That,” she said, “is not approval.”

The cavern trembled. Ripples ran across the lake.

Jory’s eyes darted. “Is it collapsing?”

“Maybe shifting,” Mara said. “We move. Now.”

They ran—carefully, because panic makes stupid feet—back along the stone path as a deeper rumble rolled through the cavern like thunder trapped underground. A stalactite snapped somewhere with a sound like a breaking bone.

Mara’s mind stayed clear, counting steps, tracking balance. Courage wasn’t the absence of fear. It was moving forward while fear tried to glue you to the ground.

They reached the shore as dust drifted from the ceiling. The tunnel they had come through looked the same, but the air felt heavier, as if the cave was holding its breath.

Jory clutched his chest. “Please tell me you know the way out.”

Mara held the glowing bottle close. “I know the way back,” she said. “But the cave may choose a different way.”

“And that’s supposed to make me feel better?”

“No,” Mara admitted. “It’s supposed to make you ready.”

Chapter 4: The Test of the Spirals

They hurried through the tunnel, headlamp on now, its beam bouncing over wet stone. The glowing veins faded as they climbed, and darkness closed in behind them like a curtain.

At the split wall, the opening was still there. But the seam shuddered, as if it wanted to close.

Mara grabbed Jory’s sleeve and pushed him through first. “Go,” she said.

Jory stumbled into the basin outside. “Mara, hurry!”

Mara stepped through and turned back just as the wall rumbled. The stone disc in its dent vibrated, and the whisper rose to a sharp hiss.

Mara didn’t yank the disc out. That could jam the mechanism. Instead, she pressed her palm flat against it and felt the vibration. The spirals under her skin seemed to guide her hand—clockwise, then a pause, then counterclockwise, like a lock with a pattern.

She turned the disc gently, following the rhythm.

The hiss softened. The wall stopped shuddering.

Jory stared. “You... you just calmed it down.”

Mara pulled the disc free and placed it back into the hidden hollow under the lever rock. “No,” she said. “I listened.”

As soon as the disc was returned, the wall slid shut with a heavy finality. The seam disappeared, leaving only carvings and silence. The basin felt ordinary again, except for the faint mineral scent and the fact that the air was much too still.

Jory let out a laugh that sounded like it had been squeezed out of him. “Okay. So the secret cave closes itself. Great. How do we get back over the bridge before it decides to throw us off?”

Mara scanned the basin. The rumbling had stopped, but the ground held a tense quiet, like a dog deciding whether to bark.

“We don’t run,” Mara said. “We move smart.”

They started down the passage toward the natural bridge. The shadows between ferns seemed deeper now. At the bridge’s edge, Mara paused, looking at the grooves on the stone again.

Jory leaned close. “Are you reading rocks now?”

“Trying,” Mara said. She traced the grooves. They weren’t random scratches. The lines showed a spiral path and—there, near the end—a carving of two hands again.

A sudden gust shot up the gorge, and the bridge sang with a low, haunting note. Jory flinched.

Mara set her boot on the first step of stone. The bridge felt solid. Old, but solid.

Halfway across, a sharp clatter echoed from the cliff above them. Pebbles rained down, bouncing and skittering into the mist.

Jory ducked. “Mara!”

Mara didn’t duck too late. She saw the source: a loose shelf of rock above,

cracking from the earlier tremor. It wouldn't collapse all at once, but pieces could fall.

"Keep moving," Mara said, voice steady. "Don't look up. Watch your feet. Trust the stone."

Jory did as told, jaw tight, breathing fast.

A larger stone dropped, thudding onto the bridge behind them and breaking into chunks. Jory yelped and bolted forward.

"Mara!" he cried. "I'm moving! I'm moving a lot!"

Mara allowed herself one quick glance back. The bridge surface had chips, but it held.

She quickened her pace—fast enough to escape, slow enough to stay upright. At the far side, she grabbed Jory by the shoulder and pulled him behind a thicker outcrop where falling stones couldn't reach.

They stood there, listening to the last pebbles tick-tick-tick into the gorge. The wind's hum returned to a calmer tone.

Jory wiped sweat from his forehead. "So," he said breathlessly, "how do you stay so calm? Are you secretly made of stone too?"

Mara's eyes stayed on the bridge. "I don't stay calm," she said. "I choose calm. Over and over. It's like picking a path. Sometimes you pick it with shaking hands."

Jory nodded, as if that made sense in the way important things often do.

Mara opened her pack and checked the bottle. The water still glowed softly, as if it carried a little piece of the cave's light.

Jory stared at it. "So... we found it. The amazing spring."

"Yes," Mara said. "But finding is only the first part."

"Uh-oh," Jory muttered. "That sounds like adult talk."

Mara looked toward the valley, where faint smoke from village chimneys curled into the sky. "We can't just pour this into every bucket and hope for miracles," she said. "If it's powerful, it needs care. And if it's scarce, it needs fairness."

Jory frowned. "Fairness like... sharing?"

"Exactly." Mara's tone became firm. "And that means we return, we test, we plan, and we tell the truth. Even if the truth is complicated."

Jory looked at the gorge, at the bridge, at the cliffs with their ancient symbols. "Do you think the people who made that cave... they were trying to keep it safe from greedy people?"

Mara's gaze sharpened with recognition. "I think so," she said quietly. "And now it's our turn."

Chapter 5: The Village Council and the Empty Cup

By the time they reached the first village, dusk had painted the valley in copper and violet. Dogs barked, not angrily, just to announce that strangers had returned. Children paused their games to stare at Mara's dusty boots and Jory's scraped knuckles.

In the main square, a circle of elders and workers gathered beneath a woven canopy. Lanterns flickered, casting warm light on tired faces. Water jars sat nearby, some only half full.

Mara placed the glowing bottle on the table. The light pulsed faintly against the wood.

A woman with silver braids leaned forward, eyes narrowing. "Is it real?"

"It's real," Mara said. "And it's unusual."

A murmur rippled through the crowd—hope, hunger, and something sharper.

A tall man with a sunburned neck spoke quickly. "Then we should send men tomorrow. Strong ones. Bring back barrels."

"Wait," Mara said, her voice still calm but cutting through the noise. "The spring is protected. It's in a cavern beyond a natural bridge, and the entrance responds to a mechanism. The area is unstable. If you rush it, you could lose people, or damage the source."

The tall man scoffed. "We've climbed cliffs since before you were born."

Mara met his eyes without flinching. "Then you know cliffs don't care how proud you are."

Jory stood a little straighter beside her. "Also, it kind of... closes itself."

The crowd chuckled nervously.

The silver-braided woman tapped the table. "What does the water do?"

Mara took a breath. "I don't know yet. It may be safe. It may not. It may have effects beyond simple drinking. We will test it."

Another voice, rough and impatient: "We don't have time for tests. My brother's farm is dying. We need water now."

Mara nodded. "I understand urgency. That's why we must be smart. If this

spring becomes a fight, it will help no one."

A boy of about twelve pushed forward, holding a small clay cup. His hands trembled a little. "My little sister's sick," he said. "She can't keep water down. My mother says maybe... maybe the spring could help."

The square went quiet. Even the dogs stopped barking, as if they were listening too.

Mara felt the weight of every eye. She could have poured the glowing water into the cup right then. It would have been dramatic. It would have been easy.

It would also have been reckless.

Mara knelt so she was level with the boy. "What's your sister's name?" she asked.

"Lina."

Mara nodded. "I won't promise magic," she said gently. "But I will not ignore her. We'll take a tiny amount to the healer tonight. If the healer agrees, we'll try it in a careful way."

The boy's fingers tightened around the cup. "Just a tiny amount?"

Mara glanced at the villagers. "Generosity isn't the same as grabbing," she said. "If we empty the spring, it may never recover. If we argue over it, the strongest will drink first and the weakest last. That is not what any of you want."

The tall man opened his mouth, but the silver-braided woman lifted a hand. "And if we ration it," she said slowly, "and share it... we all have a chance."

Mara nodded. "Yes. And we learn how to protect it. Together."

Jory leaned toward Mara and whispered, "You're doing the calm voice again. The

one that makes people feel slightly guilty.”

Mara whispered back, “It’s not guilt. It’s direction.”

The council decided, after much talking and a little arguing, to send a small group—two villagers, Mara, and Jory—to return in two days with testing supplies and to map a safe route. No barrels. No stampede. A plan.

That night, Mara walked to the healer’s hut with the boy and his mother. The healer was an old man with hands stained by herbs. He examined the glowing water with the serious face of someone who didn’t trust miracles.

He diluted a few drops into a spoonful of boiled water and gave it to Lina carefully. The girl’s eyes fluttered, and for a moment nothing happened.

Then Lina’s breathing eased, just slightly, as if her body had remembered how to rest.

Mara watched, heart tight. The healer raised an eyebrow. “Interesting,” he said. “Not proof. But interesting.”

Outside, the boy hugged his empty cup against his chest like a treasure. “Thank you,” he whispered.

Mara rested a hand on his shoulder. “Thank the spring,” she said. “And promise me something.”

“What?”

“When people start shouting about who deserves it most,” Mara said quietly, “you remind them that thirst doesn’t care about pride.”

The boy nodded fiercely. “I will.”

As Mara returned to her lodging, she stared up at the stars. The valley felt both

small and enormous. Somewhere beyond the cliffs, the spring glowed in its hidden bowl, waiting.

She knew, with a certainty that settled deep in her bones, that the hardest part of exploration wasn't discovering a secret.

It was deciding what to do with it.

Chapter 6: The Choice at the Hidden Door

Two days later, Mara stood again at the edge of the natural bridge, this time with Jory and two villagers: Kessa, a quiet carpenter with strong hands, and Bram, the tall sunburned man who had argued loudest.

Bram eyed the bridge with suspicion, as if it had personally offended him. "So this is the 'dangerous' rock," he muttered.

"It's not dangerous," Jory said. "It's just... dramatic."

Mara glanced at Bram. "Your courage isn't in question," she said. "Your patience is."

Bram grunted, but he didn't argue.

They crossed the bridge in careful silence, stopping once when a pebble shifted under Kessa's boot. Kessa steadied herself and laughed quietly. "I build doors," she said. "Not sky-walkways."

At the basin, Mara showed them the lever rock and the hidden hollow. She explained the disc and the pattern she had felt. Kessa listened closely, eyes sharp.

Bram crossed his arms. "So the mountain has a lock."

"In a way," Mara said. "And locks exist for a reason."

She placed the disc into the dent and turned it slowly, following the remembered rhythm. The wall split open, and cool mineral air poured out like a sigh.

Bram's mouth fell open before he caught himself. "All right," he admitted. "That's... impressive."

Inside, they moved carefully, marking the path with small chalk symbols that could be wiped away later. Mara took water samples at different points and tested pH, temperature, and mineral traces with portable kits. The numbers were unusual—high in certain salts, with trace elements that could help or harm depending on dosage.

At the spring, the mist swirled around them like a living question.

Kessa crouched and studied the carved channels. "These grooves," she said, running a finger along the stone. "They're meant to guide water into containers without spilling. And the path stones... spaced for steady steps."

Mara nodded. "Designed for careful use."

Bram looked at the glowing bowl. His face softened in the blue-green light. "My brother's farm," he said quietly, "he's stubborn. He'll pretend he's fine until his tongue cracks."

Mara capped another sample bottle. "Then he'll need help," she said. "Not shame."

Bram swallowed. "I was wrong in the council," he said, surprising even himself. "I wanted to take everything because I was scared there wouldn't be enough."

Mara met his gaze. "Fear makes us selfish," she said. "We can choose differently."

As they prepared to leave, Jory pointed toward the stone pillar nearest the shore. "There's something else carved here."

Mara stepped closer. On the pillar, beneath the spiral symbol, was a line of small marks like the tally band at the whispering wall. But these were arranged in groups, separated by a hand symbol.

Kessa tilted her head. "It's a schedule."

Mara's eyes widened as she understood. "Not a schedule," she corrected softly. "A distribution plan. Portions. Sharing over time."

Jory let out a low whistle. "The ancient people made a ration chart."

Bram stared at the marks as if they were a voice from the past speaking directly to him. "They knew," he murmured. "They knew people would fight."

Mara's fingers traced the final symbol: two hands again—offering and receiving—beneath a spiral that ended in a dot.

"The heart of it," Mara said, "is generosity."

They left the spring untouched beyond their measured samples. At the wall, Mara returned the disc to its hollow and slid the lever rock back into place.

Bram lingered, looking at the carvings. "So we can come back," he said. "But we should come back the right way."

Mara nodded. "With rules everyone agrees to," she said. "And with care for the spring itself."

On the bridge, wind rose, cool and clean. The gorge mist drifted below like a moving sea. Jory walked between the adults, still a bit jumpy, but steadier than before.

Bram cleared his throat. “Mara,” he said gruffly, “if we build a channel in the village, to carry spring water when we can bring it... Kessa could help. And I could haul stone.”

Kessa raised an eyebrow. “You hauling stone carefully? Now I’ve heard everything.”

Bram huffed. “Don’t get used to it.”

Mara listened, and a quiet satisfaction warmed her chest. Not triumph—something better. A shift.

Exploration had brought them to a hidden miracle, yes. But it was generosity—planned, measured, stubborn generosity—that would turn discovery into change.

As they reached the far side, Mara glanced back one last time at the natural bridge, its pale curve against the cliffs.

It hadn’t been built by hands, not at first.

But now it carried something human across it: courage, intelligence, resilience—and the choice to share.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What was the main purpose of the carved spirals and hand symbols found near the spring?

- To act as decorations that pleased the builders
- To instruct how the spring should be opened and shared
- To warn people to stay away forever
- To mark where treasures were buried

2) How did Mara stop the wall from closing and calm the cave mechanism when leaving?

- She smashed the disc and ran
- She pulled the disc out quickly and threw it away
- She pressed the disc, followed the spiral rhythm, and returned it carefully
- She shouted to scare the cave spirits

3) Why did Mara refuse to immediately give the glowing water to the whole village?

- Because she wanted to sell it for money later
- Because she thought the villagers did not deserve it
- Because she knew its effects were unknown and it needed careful testing and fair sharing
- Because she planned to keep the water for herself

4) What evidence in the cavern suggested the ancient people planned fair distribution of the spring?

- A tall statue holding a scale
- A line of tally-like marks arranged into groups separated by hand symbols
- A hidden chamber full of jars labelled with names
- A written law posted at the entrance

5) What caused the cave to tremble and force Mara and Jory to hurry back?

- A storm outside the valley
- An earthquake far away that shook the whole country
- A sudden shifting inside the cavern, making stalactites fall and the lake ripple
- Villagers trying to break in from the outside

6) Which character changed their mind about taking water immediately and later helped plan cautious use?

- Jory, who wanted to keep the water for himself
- Kessa, who originally wanted to sell the water
- Bram, who first argued to take barrels but later agreed to careful sharing
- The silver-braided woman, who always opposed sharing

Correct answers:

1) To instruct how the spring should be opened and shared 2) She pressed the disc, followed the spiral rhythm, and returned it carefully 3) Because she knew its effects were unknown and it needed careful testing and fair sharing 4) A line of tally-like marks arranged into groups separated by hand symbols 5) A sudden shifting inside the cavern, making stalactites fall and the lake ripple 6) Bram, who first argued to take barrels but later agreed to careful sharing

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Gorge: A deep, narrow valley with steep sides, often with water at the bottom.

Creases: Lines or folds made when paper or cloth is folded many times.

Natural bridge: A rock formation that forms a bridge across a gap without being built.

Mineral: A simple, non-living substance found in rocks and soil.

Grooves: Long, narrow cuts or channels carved into a surface.

Carvings: Shapes or pictures cut into wood or stone by hand.

Basin: A hollow area that can hold water like a bowl in the ground.

Seam: A thin line where two parts meet or where something can open.

Bioluminescent: Producing light from inside a living thing, like some tiny creatures.

Stalactites: Pointed pieces of rock that hang down from a cave ceiling.

Tally marks: Short lines used together to count or record numbers.

Mechanism: A system of parts that work together to do a task or open something.